

with material demonstrations of our affection, and it never feels like enough. Then, we have to work harder in order to maintain or even increase the level of gifting that we now feel is expected, and we lose out on more time and connection. It never ends.

Exercise: Unpacking our need to spend on other people

Think about the role that this plays in your life. Are there ways that you perpetuate a cycle of feeling inadequate and trying to make up for lost time or to assuage guilt by buying things for other people? Does it now feel impossible to stop that snowball effect? How does it really make you feel? Are you feeling used up? Burnt out? Harassed or resentful? There are a few ways that we can try to resolve those feelings and move forward to healthier ways of expressing love and generosity, but almost all of these things involve figuring out and enforcing new boundaries.

Ways to be generous without overspending:

- Write a thoughtful letter
- Take the time to really listen to someone
- Share skills, resources and insights
- Pass on or share things that you already have
- Offer your time, or a non-financial favour